

Memo

To: Dr. Derek G. Ross, Dr. Stewart Whittemore, and Dr. Susan Youngblood

From: V. Jasey Herrington

Re: Culinary Chronicles Meta-Analysis

Date: January 17th, 2026

Audience and Purpose

The Culinary Chronicles assignment served as the culmination of my semester in ENGL 7000: Technical Editing. Its purpose as an academic assignment was to build an editing project from conception to publication. The audience for this collaborative cultural cookbook was twofold: outside contributors and our instructor, Dr. Ross. Contributors to the publication needed the guidance from our editorial team to submit their personal recipes, while our readers and professor required a text that was accessible, usable, and followed established editing principles. As a result, *Culinary Chronicles* was used not only to present a collection of personal recipes, but also to model effective technical editing practices by prioritizing clarity, usability, and rhetorical awareness throughout the document.

My role in the creation process was that of lead editor. This required me to develop skills in supervisory oversight and hands-on editorial labor. In this role, I was responsible for guiding the project from proposal to product, developing and maintaining the style guide, coordinating with peers, and ensuring consistency across contributions where possible. This position sharpened my ability to make principled editorial decisions, mediate differing perspectives within the group, and maintain a cohesive vision for the publication while allowing for responsiveness and flexibility in collaborative input.

Goals and Editing Process

The project goals guided both the editing process and the framework we followed to create and edit the cookbook. One of our primary goals was to develop a style guide that reduced ambiguity for contributors who had varying levels of writing experience. Rather than functioning strictly as a prescriptive document, this guide supported consistency, and improved efficiency across the editing process. This also helped prioritize clarity and accessibility in the final publication through standardized formatting and consistent recipe elements.

Our editing process unfolded in multiple stages. Early in the semester, we focused on defining the rhetorical situation by identifying audience needs, assignment expectations, and publication constraints, drawing on principles from Cunningham that texts are shaped by their context (Cunningham et al., 2021). As submissions were collected throughout the semester, our team coordinated copyediting that addressed clarity and consistency at a close-editing level, while also updating the style guide when patterns emerged identifying areas of confusion. Collaboration was essential to this project, as editing required negotiation, compromise, and an awareness on my part of differing perspectives and skill sets.

Theories

Several theoretical frameworks informed my approach to this publication and its editing process. As mentioned, rhetorical situation theory informed our initial decisions on audience and purpose. Scholarship on style guides as ethical and rhetorical tools came from Adhya (2015) and Clem and Cheek's (2022) and worked respectively to shape our emphasis on usability and consistency. Finally, theories of collaborative editing and social negotiation (Amare & Manning, 2009) reinforced the idea of technical editing as relational and process-oriented practice.

Works Cited

- Adhya, N. (2015). *Style guides as rhetorical tools: Standardization, flexibility, and ethics*. *Journal of Technical Writing and Communication*, 45(4), 391–409.
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- Amare, N., & Manning, A. (2009). Editing as a social practice: The collaborative dimension of technical communication. *Technical Communication Quarterly*, 18(4), 355–377.
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Clem, L., & Cheek, J. (2022). Style guides as ethical documents: Consistency, accessibility, and editorial responsibility. *Technical Communication*, 69(2), 123–137.

Cunningham, D., Fitzgerald, S., & Simmons, A. (2021). *Technical editing* (6th ed.). Pearson.